

Exploring Human-AI Collaborative Writing of Product Descriptions on Online Flea Market Apps from the Sellers' and Buyers' Perspectives

Miyuki Fujiwara
Mercari R4D
Mercari, Inc.
Tokyo, Japan
mfujiwara@mercari.com

Rintaro Chujo
Graduate School of Interdisciplinary
Information Studies
The University of Tokyo
Tokyo, Japan
chujo@hc.ic.i.u-tokyo.ac.jp

Ari Hautasaari
Interfaculty Initiative in Information
Studies
The University of Tokyo
Tokyo, Japan
a.hautasaari@iii.u-tokyo.ac.jp

Abstract

Online flea market apps have become popular, particularly in Japan, as a means for individuals to sell used items to other individuals. The process of listing an item to be sold involves sellers uploading photographs and writing a product description to be viewed by potential buyers. Reducing the sellers' workload during the item listing process has recently emerged as one application area for human-AI collaboration by leveraging Large Language Models (LLMs) in product description writing. In this research, we explore how LLM-based support may impact the experience of sellers and the listing price of items, as well as the subjective impressions and preferences of buyers regarding the attractiveness of human-AI collaboratively written item descriptions. The research results contribute to our understanding on how LLM-based tools may impact online second-hand markets, and provides insights on design considerations and future research directions for developing human-AI collaborative writing systems for flea market apps.

CCS Concepts

• **Information systems** → **Social networking sites**; • **Human-centered computing** → **Interaction paradigms**; **Collaborative interaction**.

Keywords

human-AI collaborative writing, customer-to-customer, flea market app, product description

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1 Introduction

Online customer-to-customer (CtoC) sharing economy involves individuals trading goods, spaces and skills. Examples of CtoC markets for physical items include auction and shopping sites, such as eBay¹. A unique form of sharing economy [12] known as "flea market services" has developed in Japan, where registered users are able to sell and buy used items and handmade goods through online platforms commonly known as 'flea market apps'. The largest flea market app in Japan, Mercari, has been operating since 2013 and currently reaches approximately 22 million monthly users². The main difference between online CtoC apps and business-to-customer (BtoC) e-commerce sites, such as Amazon³, is that the majority of both sellers and buyers are general users as opposed to storefronts. Consequently, the individuals looking to sell their used or unwanted items on the flea market apps are required to contribute the item information (e.g., photos, product descriptions) and set the item pricing on the app by themselves, while also interacting with potential buyers through text-based communication channels to provide additional information or engage in price negotiations [5]. In fact, customers on flea market apps can be roughly categorized along these two aspects as either service and product-oriented or interpersonal-oriented individuals requiring platform designers to consider both when developing their user interfaces [5, 15, 18].

Previous research has reported on both item listing and seller-buyer communication processes, and proposed supporting technology on each aspect of flea market app interactions. For example, Maseki et al. [15] explored how automatic age-specific customization of product descriptions on flea market apps with LLM-based systems would influence buyers' purchase intention and impressions about the product. Recent research has also proposed additional paralinguistic cues for the lean text-based seller-buyer communication channels on CtoC flea market apps to reduce the anxiety and uncertainty of communicating with unknown individuals [5, 8, 9], which has been identified as one barrier for entry in online CtoC markets [5].

However, existing research on how to support *sellers* on CtoC flea market apps is notably scarce. Individual sellers are responsible for providing all the relevant product information which the buyers use to inform their purchase decision, and writing attractive product descriptions can be challenging especially for new

¹<https://www.ebay.com/>

²https://about.mercari.com/press/news/articles/20230630_infographics/ (in Japanese)

³<https://www.amazon.com/>

users⁴. In traditional BtoC e-commerce context, while high quality product descriptions have not been directly linked to higher purchase intention, high quality descriptions lead to higher product affective involvement, platform enduring involvement and platform situational involvement which in turn have a positive effect on purchase intention [16]. Zhang et al. [20] and Zhang et al. [21] proposed two systems, respectively, for automatically generating product descriptions on e-commerce sites, whereas Fukumoto et al. [6, 7] proposed a method for evaluating the quality of the automatically generated product descriptions, but aside from Maseki et al. [15] few previous studies have focused on the online CtoC market. Now that human-AI collaborative writing is widespread in various domains, it is important to investigate how LLM-based writing support influences sellers' experiences when listing products on CtoC flea market apps as well. Moreover, it is also crucial to examine how product descriptions collaboratively written with AI may affect the *buyers'* impressions regarding a product, which may in turn influence their purchase intention.

Presently, two online flea market platforms in Japan, Mercari⁵ and Yahoo! Furima⁶, have implemented human-AI collaborative product description writing support tools for sellers. On both flea market apps, the LLM-based system automatically generates a user-editable product description text based on the item photos uploaded by the seller. However, while online flea market apps have already implemented LLM-based support to aid their customers, little is known on how these tools affect the sellers' experiences, the potential buyers' impressions and purchase intention, or the online second-hand markets as a whole. Furthermore, no previous research has addressed how LLM-based support tools should be designed to best aid the customers in the product listing process while navigating the potential trade-offs in implementing such technology.

In this paper, we adopt the LLM-support approach similar to Mercari and Yahoo! Furima (i.e., user-editable product descriptions generated from item photos) and simulate an online flea market item listing process from the sellers' perspective (Experiment 1). We then explore how buyers perceive product descriptions written solely by AI based on item photos or through human-AI collaborative writing (Experiment 2). Our results inform the design and suggest future directions for research on the impact of human-AI collaborative writing support systems for product descriptions on online flea market apps and CtoC markets as a whole.

2 Experiment 1: Human-AI Collaborative Product Description Writing from the Sellers' Perspective

We conducted an experiment to explore how LLM-based product description writing support affects sellers' experience. In this paper, we focus on product descriptions generated solely by AI (GPT-4o) and product descriptions created through human-AI collaborative writing. Based on previous research suggesting that the ability to edit LLM outputs increases writers' satisfaction [14], sense of ownership [3, 19] and sense of authenticity/honesty towards the

authored text [4], as well as lowers their sense of guilt for using AI for writing support [4], we formulated the following hypotheses.

Hypotheses 1-3: Satisfaction (H1), sense of ownership (H2) and honesty (H3) towards written product descriptions are rated higher when sellers are able to edit automatically generated LLM outputs.

H4: Guilt of using AI assistance for writing product descriptions is rated lower when sellers are able to edit automatically generated LLM outputs.

Secondly, while considering the inconclusive results reported in previous research on human-AI collaborative writing and authors' subjective workload [1, 2, 17], we formulated our first research question as follows:

RQ1: How does human-AI collaboration affect the sellers' subjective workload when writing product descriptions on flea market apps?

Draxler et al. [3] reported on arguments both for and against using labels to disclose AI involvement in texts produced through human-AI collaborative writing. We wanted to explore how disclosing AI involvement in product descriptions influences sellers' perceptions on flea market apps and asked the following research question:

RQ2: How does the presence of a label disclosing AI involvement in product description writing influence the sellers subjective experience?

Lastly, as flea market apps involve selling and buying items, we wanted to investigate whether and how human-AI collaboration in product description writing would influence the listing price of items (i.e., the initial price set by sellers):

RQ3: Does human-AI collaborative product description writing influence item pricing? If so, how?

2.1 Participants

We recruited 21 participants for this experiment through a Japanese recruiting company (11 female, 10 male, mean age 37.90 years, SD=9.06). At the recruitment stage, participation was limited to those who had experience buying and selling items on online flea market apps, as well as using generative AI tools, such as ChatGPT. Informed consent was obtained from the participants at the start of the experiment. The participants had no prior knowledge of this study and were paid 6,000 yen for their participation through the recruiting company. The experiment protocol underwent review and received approval from the ethical committee at the first and last authors' institutions, respectively, and the experiment was conducted between 18th and 29th of August, 2024.

2.2 Procedure

The experiment was conducted on Google Meet. The participants were tasked with "selling" two items on an experimental app that mimicked a flea market app (Figure 1). They were instructed to prepare two items that they had actually used and were fond of ahead of the experiment. The participants were explicitly informed that they would not actually sell the items, and that the experiment was merely a simulation.

⁴https://about.mercari.com/press/news/articles/20240910_aisupport/ (in Japanese)

⁵https://about.mercari.com/press/news/articles/20240910_aisupport/ (in Japanese)

⁶<https://paypayfleamarket.yahoo.co.jp/> (in Japanese)

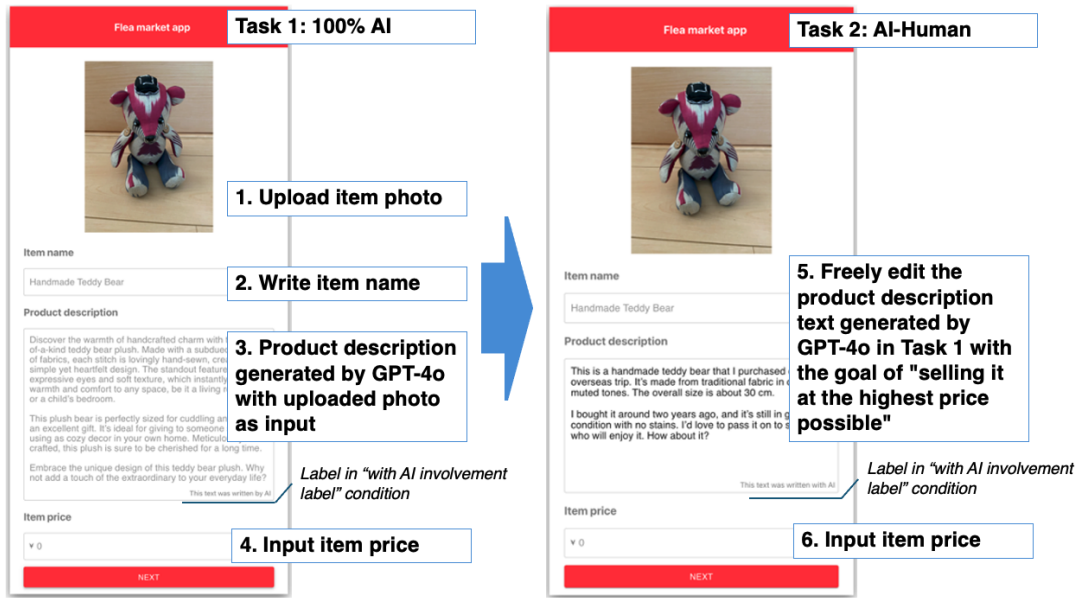


Figure 1: Experiment application and experiment flow for Task 1 and Task 2. Original Japanese interface translated to English by the authors.

In the "100% AI" task, the participants were asked to (1) take and upload a photo of the item and (2) write the item name. (3) A product description generated by GPT-4o with the photo as input was displayed, and (4) the participants were asked to input the item listing price. After answering a questionnaire, the participants moved to the "AI-Human" task, in which they (5) freely edited the product description generated by GPT-4o in Task 1 with the goal of "selling it at the highest price possible", and (6) input the listing price again.

Each participant "sold" two items following the procedure in Figure 1. Based on previous research by Draxler et al. [3], two types of labels were displayed ("This text was written by AI" and "This text was written with AI" in Japanese) indicating the degree of AI involvement. Participants experienced either condition (with and without the AI involvement label) per item, where the order of the conditions was counter-balanced between participants.

We employed the think-aloud method, in which participants were asked to speak their thoughts aloud while working on the experiment tasks in order to record their introspective information in detail. The participants completed an online questionnaire after each task. The questionnaire⁷ was designed based on previous research [3, 4, 13] and findings from preliminary interviews and experiment, as well as the six subscales of the Japanese version

of the NASA Task Load Index (NASA-TLX) [10, 11]. Lastly, they participated in a semi-structured interview.

2.3 Results

In order to explore the effects of AI support on sellers' subjective experience during a product description writing task, we conducted two-way repeated measures ANOVA analyses with the task (100% AI and AI-Human) and the presence or absence of an AI involvement label as within-subjects factors.

2.3.1 Satisfaction, Ownership, Honesty and Guilt. The results showed a significant main effect for task (100% AI vs. AI-Human) for 'Satisfaction' ($F[1, 20] = 44.80, p < .05$), 'Ownership' ($F[1, 20] = 61.65, p < .05$) and 'Honesty' ($F[1, 20] = 64.04, p < .05$), where the average ratings were significantly higher for the AI-human task ('Satisfaction': $M=8.55, SD=1.89$; 'Ownership': $M=7.07, SD=2.73$; 'Honesty': $M=8.86, SD=1.68$) compared to the 100% AI task ('Satisfaction': $M=5.31, SD=3.08$; 'Ownership': $M=3.14, SD=2.42$; 'Honesty': $M=4.90, SD=3.00$) and significantly lower for 'Guilt' ($F[1, 20] = 38.06, p < .05$) in the AI-Human ($M = 1.71, SD = 1.15$) compared to the 100% AI ($M = 4.36, SD = 3.50$) task. The main effect of AI involvement label (with vs. without) and the interaction effect between task and AI involvement label were not significant in any of the comparisons. H1, H2, H3 and H4 were supported, and the results partially answered our RQ2 (see below).

2.3.2 Workload (NASA-TLX). The results showed a significant main effect for task (100% AI vs. AI-Human) ($F[1, 20] = 6.26, p < .05$) where the average workload was lower for the AI-Human task, but no significant main effect for AI involvement label (with vs. without) ($F[1, 20] = 0.03, p = .86$). The interaction between the two was also not significant ($F[1, 20] = 1.23, p = .28$). Planned post-hoc

⁷The questionnaire items were as follows (in Japanese, translated to English by authors). Each was answered on a 10-point scale (1=not at all, 10=very).

- How satisfied are you with the writing? (Satisfaction)
- How satisfied are you with the price you set? (Price satisfaction)
- How much do you think your writing is your own? (Ownership)
- How honestly do you think you wrote the completed product description? (Honesty)
- As a seller, do you feel guilty about using AI to write your product description? (Guilt)

analyses revealed that both 'Performance' (reverse scale) and 'Frustration' were significantly higher in the 100% AI task (Performance: $M = 47.12, SD = 27.70$, Frustration: $M = 32.81, SD = 32.18$) compared to the AI-Human task (Performance: $M = 20.52, SD = 20.62$, Frustration: $M = 15.17, SD = 16.31$) ($p < .05$). This result answered our RQ1. The sellers experienced a lower subjective workload due to higher perceived performance and lower frustration when they were able to edit the AI generated product descriptions. This result further answered our RQ2. The AI involvement label did not have a significant effect on the sellers' subjective experience when using AI support to write product descriptions.

2.3.3 Impact of Human-AI collaboration in product description writing on item pricing and pricing satisfaction. To answer RQ3, we used the item pricing by the participants along with the think-aloud data from the experiment, and compared the change in item price from the 100% AI task to AI-Human task. The participants were most likely to increase the price after editing the AI-generated product description: 21/42 items with price increase, 16/42 items with no price change, 5/42 items with price decrease. The participants also rated their 'Pricing Satisfaction' as significantly higher in the AI-Human task ($M = 8.40, SD = 1.89$) compared to the 100% AI task ($M = 7.31, SD = 2.48$): $F[1, 20] = 6.08, p < .05$.

Focusing on the reasons for the price increase, we analyzed the think-aloud data from the experiment. The most common reasons for price increase were participants being able to omit redundant (5/21 participants) or add missing information (5/21 participants) to the AI-generated text (ID56: "I was able to add personal information, such as the fact that I care about the shipping method."). Furthermore, some participants explained that editing the AI-generated text made it more trustworthy (5/21 participants), and hence raised the price of the product (ID51: "I was able to correct the mistake. I think the other party will trust me now.").

3 Experiment 2: Human-AI Collaboratively Written Product Descriptions from the Buyers' Perspective

We conducted a crowdsourcing experiment to explore how product descriptions created with a LLM-based writing support system may affect buyers' product preference and their perception of the honesty of product descriptions on flea market apps. Specifically, we set the following research question:

RQ4: Does collaborative writing of product descriptions by sellers and AI affect buyers' product preference?

As reported in Experiment 1, sellers rated the collaboratively written product descriptions significantly higher in terms of honesty than product descriptions written fully by AI. To investigate the buyers' perceptions about the level of honesty in fully AI and AI-human collaboratively written product descriptions, we set the following research questions:

RQ5: Are product descriptions created by collaborative writing between sellers and AI rated higher in terms of honesty by buyers compared to product descriptions written fully by AI?

RQ6: How do sellers and buyers perceive the level of honesty in same product descriptions generated by AI and those written collaboratively by AI and sellers?

Furthermore, similarly to Experiment 1 and based on Draxler et al. [3], we introduced two types of labels indicating the degree of AI involvement in the writing process ("This text was written by AI" and "This text was written with AI" in Japanese) to examine how the disclosure of AI involvement in the creation of product descriptions on flea market apps is evaluated from the perspective of buyers and set the following research question:

RQ7: Do labels indicating the degree of AI involvement affect buyers' product preference and their perception of the honesty of product descriptions?

3.1 Participants

We analyzed data from 864 participants (423 female, 435 male, 6 other/prefer not to answer, mean age 49.33 years, $SD=11.67$) recruited from a Japanese crowdsourcing platform Yahoo! Crowdsourcing⁸. The requirement for participation was having experience in using flea market apps (either as a seller or a buyer) as well as having experience with generative AI, such as ChatGPT. Before the start of the experiment, informed consent was presented, and only those who agreed and met the prerequisites for flea market app and generative AI experience were allowed to participate. The participants were randomly assigned to one of two conditions (between-subjects design): "with AI involvement label" and "without AI involvement label". The experiment protocol underwent review and received approval from the ethical committee at the first and last authors' institutions, respectively, and was conducted between November 26th and December 9th, 2024.

3.2 Procedure

The participants were directed to an experiment website where they filled an informed consent and answered a demographic questionnaire. Next, an instructional text explained the experiment task role-play scenario. The participants were told that they were about to purchase an item on a flea market app, and that on flea market apps, sellers can not only write the product description themselves, but also use AI. In the "with AI involvement label" group, participants were informed that the person who wrote the product description would be displayed at the end of the product description (similarly to Figure 1).

The participants were presented with a screen where two versions of one item were displayed side-by-side with "100% AI" or "AI-Human" product descriptions including the same item image and item name, but without a listing price. The item was randomly selected for each participant from the 42 items created in Experiment 1⁹, and each item was included for both with and without AI involvement label groups. The order of the product description (100% AI or AI-Human) was randomized. The participants were instructed as follows: "You would like to buy this product. Please

⁸<https://crowdsourcing.yahoo.co.jp/>

⁹Permission to use the item images and text in Experiment 2 was obtained from the Experiment 1 participants as part of their informed consent. The images were checked by the authors for any identifying information, anonymized when appropriate, and watermarked with the experiment information prior to uploading to the Experiment 2 platform.

compare the two product descriptions and choose the one you would like to purchase" (in Japanese). Next, the participants were asked to rate how honestly they felt each of the two product descriptions were written. Instead of displaying two product descriptions side by side, the experiment web page displayed the item with both product descriptions (100% AI or AI-Human) one at a time in sequence. The order was randomized for each participant. The following instructions were displayed in Japanese: "How honest do you think the following product description is?" (1-not at all, 10-very) (in Japanese). Lastly, a concentration check was administered where the participants were asked to choose the item presented in the experiment from three options and indicate whether they had participated in the experiment "with AI involvement label" or "without AI involvement label". Participants who answered incorrectly to either question were omitted from the analyses leaving data from 16 to 28 participants for each item in both groups.

3.3 Results

3.3.1 The impact of human-AI collaboration in product description writing on product preference. To explore how buyers' preference changes depending on whether a product description is written fully by AI or through human-AI collaboration, we focused on the distribution of the number of selections for each task (100% AI and AI-Human) and conducted a binomial test to analyze if the proportions were equal. As a result, 580 participants selected AI-Human and 284 participants selected 100% AI, and the degree of preference was significantly different depending on the task ($p < .001$). To confirm whether there was independence between the task and the presence or absence of the AI-involvement label, we created a cross-tabulation table (Table 1) and conducted a chi-square test. Based on the results it was determined that the task and the AI-involvement label were independent ($\chi^2[1] = 3.10, p = .078$). These results answered our RQ4. The buyers preferred the human-edited product descriptions over fully AI-generated descriptions, and disclosing the degree of AI involvement did not significantly influence this preference (RQ7).

Table 1: Product preference in each task depending on the presence or absence of the AI involvement label

	AI-Human	100%AI	Total
Without AI Involvement Label	276	154	430
With AI Involvement Label	304	130	434
Total	580	284	864

3.3.2 Buyers' perception of honesty in product descriptions written with AI support. To investigate the buyers' perception of honesty in product descriptions written by or with AI, as well as to explore the differences between buyers' and sellers' perceptions, we compared the data from Experiment 1 on sellers' ratings of 'Honesty' with the data from buyers in Experiment 2. We conducted a Mixed ANOVA with role (buyer vs. seller) as between-subjects, and task (100% AI vs. AI-Human) and AI involvement label (with vs. without) as within-subjects factors. The main effect of role ($F[1, 883] = .12, p = .72$) was not significant. The main effect of task ($F[1, 883] = 492.78, p < .0001$), and the interaction between

role and task ($F[1, 883] = 173.60, p < .0001$) were significant. While the main effect of AI involvement label ($F[1, 883] = 10.00, p = .03$) and the interaction between role and AI involvement label ($F[1, 883] = 10.43, p = .03$) were significant, there was no significant effect of AI involvement label observed in pair-wise comparisons for buyer ($F[1, 883] = 0.02, p = .94$) or seller ($F[1, 20] = 1.51, p = .23$) (see: Experiment 1). Buyers perceived a higher level of honesty in product descriptions that were collaboratively written by sellers and AI ($M=7.44, SD=1.66$) compared to descriptions generated fully by AI ($M=6.44, SD=1.89$) similarly to sellers who wrote the product descriptions (RQ5, RQ6). Disclosing the degree of AI involvement did not significantly influence this perception (RQ7). The degree to which human editing of AI-generated product descriptions increased the perceived level of honesty was dependent on whether they were evaluated by buyers (mean increase of 1.01) or sellers (mean increase of 3.95).

4 Discussion

Our two experiments explored how LLM-based human-AI collaborative writing of product descriptions influences sellers' and buyers' experiences on online CtoC flea market apps. Similarly to previous research in other human-AI collaborative writing domains, the results from Experiment 1 suggest that when sellers are involved in the editing of AI generated product descriptions, they perceive a higher level of satisfaction (H1), sense of ownership (H2) and honesty (H3) towards the product description text [3, 4, 14, 19], as well as lower level of guilt (H4) from using AI support [4]. After editing AI-generated product descriptions, the sellers also reported a lower subjective workload due to higher perceived performance and lower level of frustration (RQ1) [1, 2, 17]. However, adding a label to indicate whether a description was fully written by AI or through human-AI collaboration did not have a significant effect on the sellers' subjective experiences (RQ2) [3].

Interestingly, the majority of participants acting as sellers set a higher listing price for their items after editing the AI generated product description, and reported a higher level of satisfaction on the set price due to being able to omit and add information leading to a more trustworthy description in comparison to fully AI-generated text (RQ3). This result implies that human-AI collaborative writing support, and specifically the sellers' ability to edit AI-generated product descriptions, may influence the pricing of items on flea market apps. However, since our results were derived from a controlled experiment, it is imperative that future research investigates how AI support for product description writing, particularly when also compared with human-written descriptions, may influence the pricing of second-hand items on real flea market apps.

The results from Experiment 2 suggested that buyers perceive product descriptions written collaboratively with AI more attractive (RQ4) and more honest than descriptions generated fully by AI (RQ5), similarly to the sellers (RQ6). Surprisingly, disclosing the level of AI involvement did not influence the buyers' product preference, nor their perception of the honesty in the product description (RQ7). However, our results suggest that there is a gap between buyers and sellers in their perception of the "Honesty" of AI-generated descriptions and those edited by humans. Even when

sellers edit text generated by AI, the perceived level of honesty does not increase as much as sellers might expect. This may be because text alone cannot convey critical information held only by the sellers, such as the product's condition or usage context, nor can it clarify the accuracy of the information contained in AI-generated text. As a result, buyers lack sufficient information to judge the honesty of the product description generated fully by AI.

Lastly, indicating the level of AI involvement in the product listing process through labels can be thought as one method to increase mutual trust between sellers and buyers, and promote a fair CtoC marketplace as LLM-based systems are increasingly utilized by sellers. While our results did not indicate that the presence or absence of such labels would affect the perceptions of honesty in product descriptions for either sellers or buyers (RQ2, RQ7) [3], it is too early to abandon the idea of disclosing the level of AI involvement based only on this study. Future research is needed to elucidate the relationship between AI involvement and trust between flea market app customers. For example, labels indicating the extent of AI involvement (e.g., 80% vs. 20%) may affect the *degree* of trust towards a seller, which we did not measure in the present study. As LLMs continue to improve and product descriptions generated by AI become increasingly less distinguishable from human-written descriptions, it is important to pay attention to customers' attitudes and perceptions towards AI and continue to re-evaluate the necessity of disclosing AI involvement in CtoC market transactions to ensure trust both between flea market customers as well as customers and CtoC platforms.

5 Conclusion

Selling and buying used items on online CtoC flea market apps has grown in popularity, particularly in Japan, where the largest flea market app Mercari attracts approximately 22 million monthly users. In this paper, we reported on a seminal study exploring how human-AI collaborative writing of product descriptions on flea market apps influences both sellers' and buyers' experiences through controlled experiments.

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